

Chemical Warfare

The US military's technological superiority was particularly evident in the activities of the Army's Chemical Corps, which brought the products of American laboratory research straight to the battlefields of Vietnam.

◀◀ BEFORE

Chemical weapons, in the form of poisonous gas, were developed and used in World War I.

CHEMICAL R&D

The US Army's Chemical Warfare Service (CWS), founded in 1918, continued to develop gas weapons, but never used them during World War II. The CWS did, however, perfect the use of **incendiary devices** such as bombs and flamethrowers. Rebranded as the Chemical Corps in 1946, it also developed biological weapons.

Chemical warfare in Vietnam was mostly one-sided: the US was the only combatant capable of regularly deploying such weapons. The use of chemical weapons opened another front for the antiwar movement, which targeted chemical manufacturers such as Monsanto and Dow Chemical for their support of the war. Activists launched boycotts, disrupted job fairs, picketed chemical plants, and lobbied elected officials to regulate the chemical industry and rein in its ability to profit from the misery and horror of war.